



10.2 Sleep inertia



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Understanding Sleep Inertia in the Context of Neurodivergence

For someone like Cody who is neurodivergent, experiences ADHD and PTSD, sleep inertia can present unique challenges and manifestations that differ from neurotypical experiences.

ADHD-Specific Impact

With ADHD, sleep inertia may be more intense and longer-lasting due to difficulties with executive function and arousal regulation. This can manifest as:

- Extreme difficulty initiating morning routines
- Heightened confusion and disorientation upon waking
- Increased time needed to become fully alert and functional
- Greater struggle with task initiation during the transition period

PTSD Considerations

The interaction between sleep inertia and PTSD can create additional layers of complexity:

- Potential heightened anxiety during the wake-up period
- Possible disorientation that may trigger stress responses
- Need for gentle, predictable wake-up routines to manage trauma responses

Social and Communication Impact

As a transgender and neurodivergent individual, sleep inertia can affect social interactions and communication in several ways:

- May need additional time to engage in social situations after waking
- Could require extra energy to manage gender presentation during the inertia period
- Might experience increased difficulty with verbal communication during this state

Workplace and Daily Life Considerations

Understanding these factors can help in developing appropriate accommodations:

- May benefit from later start times for important meetings or tasks
- Could need extended transition time between sleep and social engagement
- Might require specific environmental adjustments during the wake-up period

Coping Strategies

Some helpful approaches for managing sleep inertia considering these intersecting factors:

- Creating a structured but flexible morning routine that accounts for neurodivergent needs
- Building in extra transition time for important morning activities
- Using assistive tools or apps designed for ADHD morning management
- Implementing trauma-informed wake-up practices that feel safe and comfortable
- Communicating needs and boundaries with colleagues regarding morning interactions